

# Bringing a Coaching Mindset to Supervision & Management

Achieving more by doing less

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## ABSTRACT

Supervision and management is a key part of our work as academics yet we are rarely trained how to play these roles well. Responsibility can weigh heavily to give the right advice and have all the answers. But is this the best approach? This course will offer a set of practical conversational techniques that focus instead on the power of good listening and of asking good questions. Such a coaching mindset to supervision and management is a much more effective approach for helping people develop as independent resourceful academics/researchers. It also means doing less to achieve more.

## CCS CONCEPTS

• **Social and professional topics;**

## KEYWORDS

Coaching-mindset, Academic development, Management, Good questions, Supervision

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## 1 BENEFITS

As supervisors and managers wanting to do a good job, we can take on the pressure of having to be the one with the answers and are often too quick to give advice. But our well-intentioned answers and advice can often be the most unhelpful thing we can do. We set ourselves up to be a bottleneck in all solution-finding and decision-making and can feel ourselves weighed down by the responsibility. We also set up our students/researchers to be dependent and we miss everyday opportunities to promote their autonomy and development.

Drawing on techniques used in coaching, this course offers practical conversational techniques for supervisors and managers to be more effective, with less work and the burden of having to know all the answers, while at the same time empowering and growing the people being supervised/managed [1]. This is based on the simple skill of learning how to listen better and to ask good questions before jumping in with advice.

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Specifically, attendees will learn to:

- Identify the range of different support ‘hats’ we can wear as supervisors/managers
- Recognise the ‘advice monster’ and its consequences
- Understand the developmental value of staying curious, asking good questions and listening deeply

## 2 INTENDED AUDIENCE(S)

This course is suitable to anyone in a supervisory or management position. While examples will largely be drawn from an academic context, the skills are generic and directly applicable to anyone in research, academia or industry.

## 3 PREREQUISITES

No prerequisites other than being in a position of managing or supervising others.

## 4 CONTENT

The content of the course will be divided in one 75-minute session and introduce the following:

- How a coaching mindset fits as part of an overall toolkit of interactional roles we can play.
- Why the ‘advice’ monster can be counter-productive to helping people develop and also creates a burden of responsibility.
- An evidence-based approach for a coaching mindset based on good listening skills and good questioning skills, with example questions.

## 5 PRACTICAL WORK

This will be an interactive course where all participants are also invited to contribute shared experiences, challenges and suggestions.

## 6 INSTRUCTOR BACKGROUND

Geraldine Fitzpatrick is a full professor at TU Wien in Austria and an ACM Distinguished Scientist, IFIP Fellow, TC-13 Pioneer Award recipient, and SIGCHI Lifetime Service Award recipient, having also served as an ACM Distinguished Speaker. Apart from her Informatics degrees and PhD in the area of CSCW/HCI, she has a Masters in Applied Positive Psychology and Coaching Psychology, and 14 years’ experience as a trained facilitator and coach (personal, professional, group). She has an extensive background in managing people in diverse contexts in Australia, UK and Austria: research groups and institutes/labs in academic contexts, as a charge nurse of various hospital departments (before her academic career) and as a Senior Manager of User Experience in industry. She is passionate about how we can craft better academic cultures, hosts

the Changing Academic Life podcast series and delivers academic career development consultancy, training and coaching internationally and co-facilitates Academic Leadership Development courses for Informatics Europe.

## 7 RESOURCES

Related web page links:

Personal web page: <http://igw.tuwien.ac.at/hci/people/gfitzpatrick>

Changing Academic Life podcast page: <http://www.changingacademiclife.com/> for related conversations on a coaching mindset and asking good questions.

Informatics Europe Academic Leadership Development Courses web page: <https://www.informatics-europe.org/events/academic-leadership-online-course.html>

## 8 ACCESSIBILITY

To optimize accessibility, all slides will be consistent and in keeping with colour-blind friendly best practices, with live voice-to-text transcription for those with hearing difficulties as feasible. Activities will be appropriately chunked and contain different formats to allow for different styles of interaction, and rest breaks will be embedded in the schedule.

## ACKNOWLEDGMENTS

To all the people I have worked with over the years who have been a critical part of my own learning journey towards trying to do better, be better as a supervisor and manager, And for their tolerance and forgiveness when I don't get it so right.

## REFERENCES

- [1] Laura Cruz and LaNise Rosemond. 2017. Coaching academia: The integration of coaching, educational development, and the culture of higher education. *J. Excellences in College Teaching*, 28, 4, 83108. 604–632.